

Sunitha Krishnan

Sunitha Krishnan (born 1972, age 54) co-founded Prajwala, Asia's largest anti-sex trafficking organization, rescuing and rehabilitating over 26,000 girls and women while preventing second-generation prostitution through education and vocational training

Education

- Master's degree in Psychiatric Social Work from School of Social Work, Roshni Nilaya, Mangalore, equipping her for counseling survivors of trauma and exploitation.

Career

Joined civil society movements in Hyderabad's red-light areas during the 1990s, advocating for sex workers amid evictions that left thousands homeless.

Co-founded Prajwala in 1996 with Brother Jose Vetticatil, starting a transition school in a vacated brothel to educate children of prostituted mothers; expanded to 17 centers, shelters, crisis counseling in police stations, and economic rehab programs in carpentry, welding, printing, and housekeeping.

Pioneered policy advocacy, training law enforcement nationwide, and drafting victim-centric laws; organization now aids survivors across 12 countries with holistic services including HIV care.

Awards and Recognition

- Padma Shri (2016), India's fourth-highest civilian honor for her anti-trafficking work.
- U.S. Department of State TIP Report Hero (2009); other honors include global recognition from TIP Heroes and advocacy platforms for policy impact.

Sunitha's Story

Sunitha's journey into activism began as a child in Hyderabad, where by age 8 she was teaching dance to slum children and by 13 organizing community welfare—acts that defied her conservative family background and foreshadowed her lifelong defiance of norms. At 15, while distributing food in red-light areas, she was abducted and gang-raped by seven men in retaliation for her interference; the 48-hour ordeal left her battered, but instead of withdrawing, she channeled the trauma into fiercer resolve, testifying publicly and pursuing psychiatric social work to heal others.

In the mid-1990s, government evictions in Hyderabad's Gandhinagar red-light district displaced 2,500 sex ---



workers and their children onto streets, with no alternatives—many girls faced immediate trafficking. Sunitha, then 23, sold her gold jewelry and personal savings to rent a single room, launching Prajwala's first "transition school" for 20 children of prostituted mothers, teaching them amid threats from traffickers who firebombed the site. Co-founding with Brother Jose in 1996, she personally rescued over 4,200 women by going undercover in brothels, negotiating with pimps, and enduring assaults; her persistence grew Prajwala from that humble start to rescuing 26,600+ survivors, educating 6,000+ children, and preventing generational cycles through mandatory schooling for at-risk kids—her 2025 memoir *I Am What I Am* chronicles these battles, arrests, and triumphs over three decades.

Leadership at Prajwala

As Chief Functionary and General Secretary, she oversees operations for 6,000+ children in schools and has rescued 26,600+ victims with 200+ staff, many survivors themselves.

Innovated prevention via 17 transition centers, economic enterprises for dignity, and police-embedded counseling; expanded to global rescues while shaping India's anti-trafficking policies.

Maintains volunteer commitment, focusing on trauma-informed rehab that achieves societal reintegration, studied as a model for ending sex slavery.